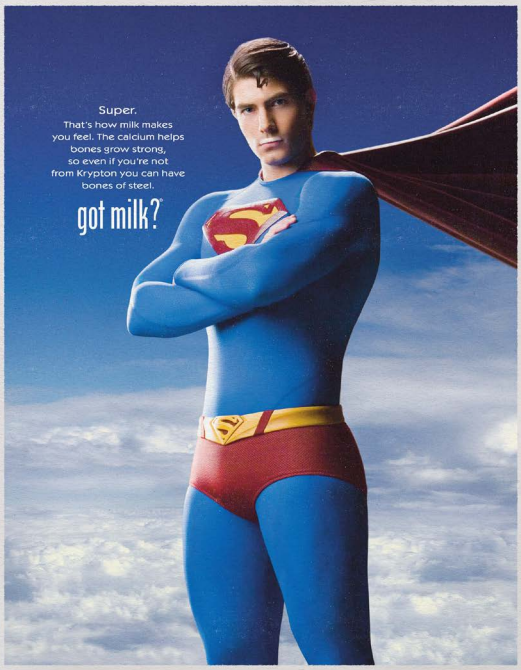
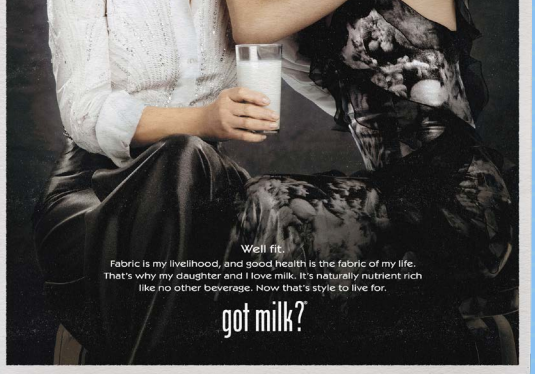
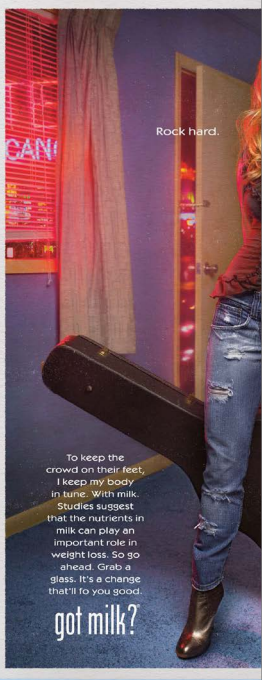








By 1997, wrote Manning, "National awareness of 'Got Milk?' would be over 80 percent and pushing 90 percent among teens."

Dairy farmers loved the campaign. "I thought it was incredible," says Alan Mann, a lifelong dairy farmer from Oregon who sells his milk to the Darigold cooperative. "It was the first thing I knew of that went viral."

Whether Got Milk? was an early-days meme or a good old-fashioned cliché, it was effective. Copycat phrases popped up everywhere. Got beer? Got hair? Got marketing? Got Jesus? The California board didn't bother suing most imitators: Mann, for his part, loved spotting these copycats, because he knew they were basically free advertising.

Milk did seem cool for a spell, but whether it got Americans to drink more milk is questionable. On the one hand, for a year or two in the mid-1990s, there was a microbump in milk drinking, as described in a corroborated 1999 study showing that milk checkoff ads caused a 6 percent hike in milk sales.

But by the end of the decade, the writing was on the wall: Americans were drinking less milk than ever, then averaging around two thirds of a cup per day per person. (By 2019, the last year with available statistics, that number would be less than a half a cup.) MilkPEP pulled the plug on the Got Milk? mustache campaign in 2014. It was the end of an era; The New Yorker wrote a eulogy.

Got Milk? could have only succeeded in the '90s. The ad campaign was forged in the crucible of the free-market optimism of the previous decade, propelled by network TV and glossy magazines at the peak of their popularity, and tinged with the wicked humor Gen X loved. Yet a single ad campaign,

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)



